on the dunes but on the built-up area instead, which has more defence potential.

It was then time for a visit to 15 Corps at Srinagar, where Lt Gen BS Raju had just taken over the Corps from Lt Gen KJS (Tiny) Dhillon, who was as different from his predecessor as chalk and cheese. I had wanted to visit the location of 8 JAT/268 Infantry Brigade in the Kupwara Sector, but the weather played spoilsport. It was near this location that we had lost five Para (SF) boys in an encounter, although they did manage to eliminate four terrorists themselves in Operation Rangdori Baikh.[11] It was just sheer bad luck that while closing in on the terrorists, a snow cornice gave way and the team went tumbling down right into the terrorist hideout, wherein a fierce firefight ensued. One of the Commandos, who luckily was still on top, managed to give some fire support and engage the terrorists. Sep Sonam Tshering, a young soldier, kept his wits and took cover behind a solitary tree, which was so slender that his rucksack and sleeping bag were riddled with bullets. This twenty-five-year-old with six years of service displayed true grit and determination, for which he was awarded the Shaurya Chakra.[12] In all my visits, I endeavoured to meet locals from all walks of life to get a feel of the place and people. I also looked up some of my acquaintances from my 2 RR days, Irfan and Adnan, whose father, Majid Bhat, had been a renowned politician. Most of the people we met were passionate nationalists, wanting to bring about positive change in Kashmir. They were almost unanimously of the view that most of the then crop of politicians and bureaucrats were totally corrupt and were thriving on narco-terrorism. On the new party that had just been launched—Apna Party—they said it was just old wine in a new bottle. It did make me pause and wonder whether such candid feedback is taken note of by the powers that be.

Copyright © Penguin Random House India Not for circulation